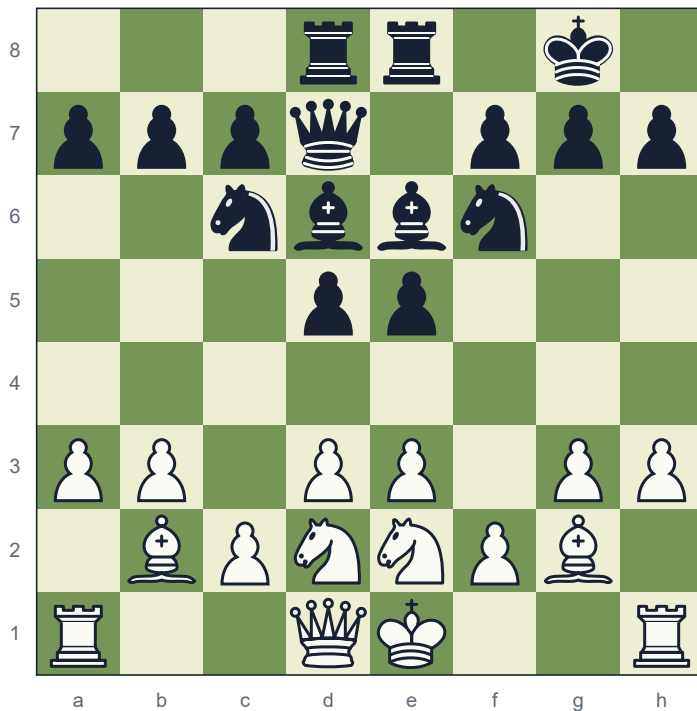


Use the extra move



HW-01 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

White has the first move but can give away its value by making ten small setup moves while Black takes the center. A reversed Hippo is a practical choice with concessions, not a guaranteed initiative.

HOW TO DECIDE

Use flexibility to select an active central challenge. Compare a useful developing move or c4 with a3 and h3 before deciding that both wing pawn moves are needed.

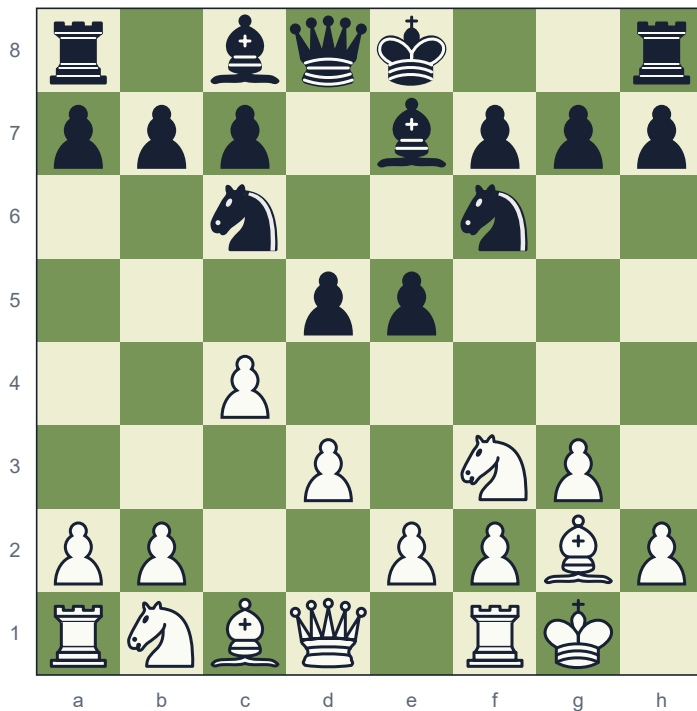
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can gain a broad center and a comfortable game. White should not rely on Black making an impatient attack.

BOARD DRILL

At a quiet endpoint, identify one setup move that could have been replaced by earlier central action.

c4, d4 or e4?



HW-19 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

c4 challenges d5; d4 contests central space directly; e4 may lead to a KIA structure. The best choice depends on Black's pawns and your knight squares.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate captures and advances before committing. Decide where the queen knight belongs afterward and whether the b2 or g2 bishop benefits from the change.

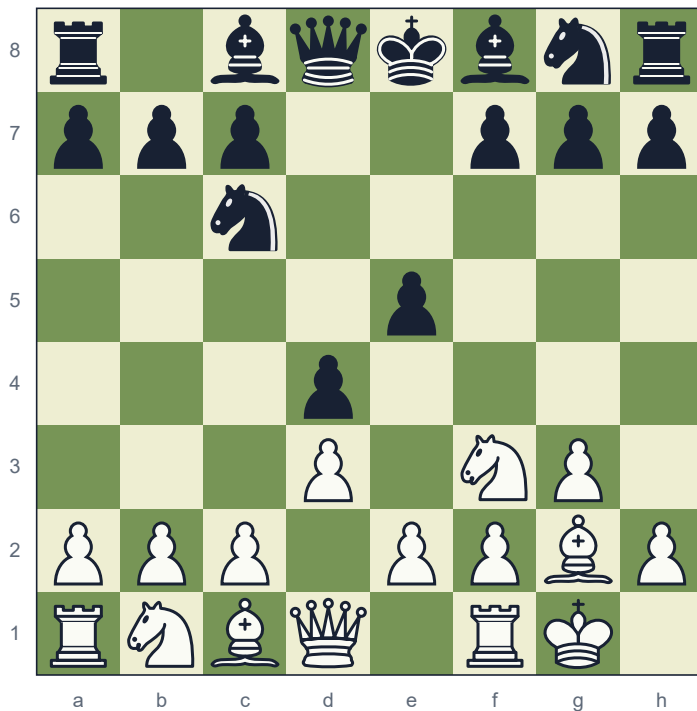
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can close the center and restrict a knight. A pawn break without a development plan can leave you with less room, not more.

BOARD DRILL

Compare the three adaptation branches and write the central pawn structure after the first exchange in each.

Ne2 versus Nf3



HW-11 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

Ne2 preserves some pawn flexibility and avoids blocking the g2 bishop's immediate diagonal, but Nf3 contests e5 and may be more urgent against a large center.

HOW TO DECIDE

Choose the knight square from its next useful job. If Black threatens ...e4, calculate whether Nf3 would be attacked; if d4 needs pressure, compare the available support.

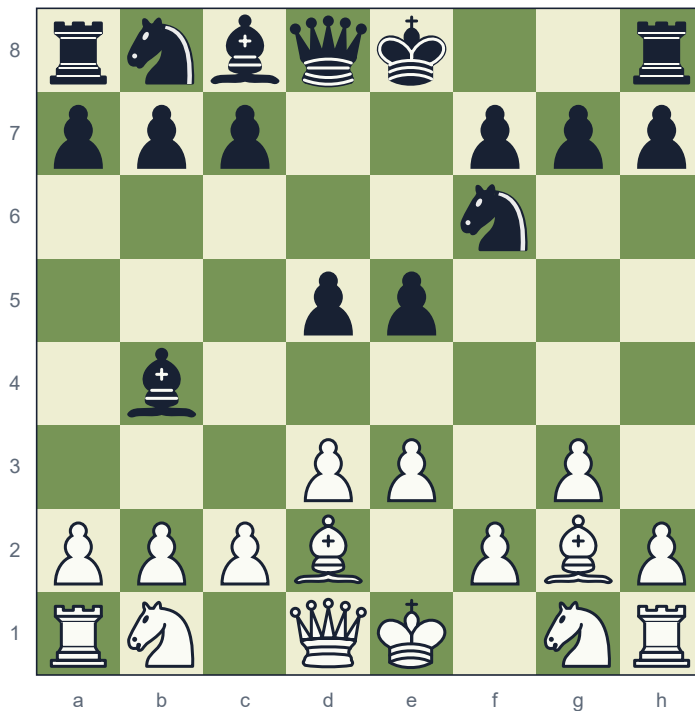
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

A rigid insistence on Ne2 can leave the center uncontested. A careless Nf3 can allow a pawn gain with tempo.

BOARD DRILL

Use two branches with different knight routes and explain the concrete central difference.

The bishop on b2 is not always best



HW-18 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

A check from ...Bb4+ may be best met with Bd2. A central opening may give the bishop a useful diagonal elsewhere. Double fianchettoing is an option, not an obligation.

HOW TO DECIDE

Choose a developing response that answers the actual threat. After an exchange, identify which diagonals remain useful and whether relocating the bishop costs too much time.

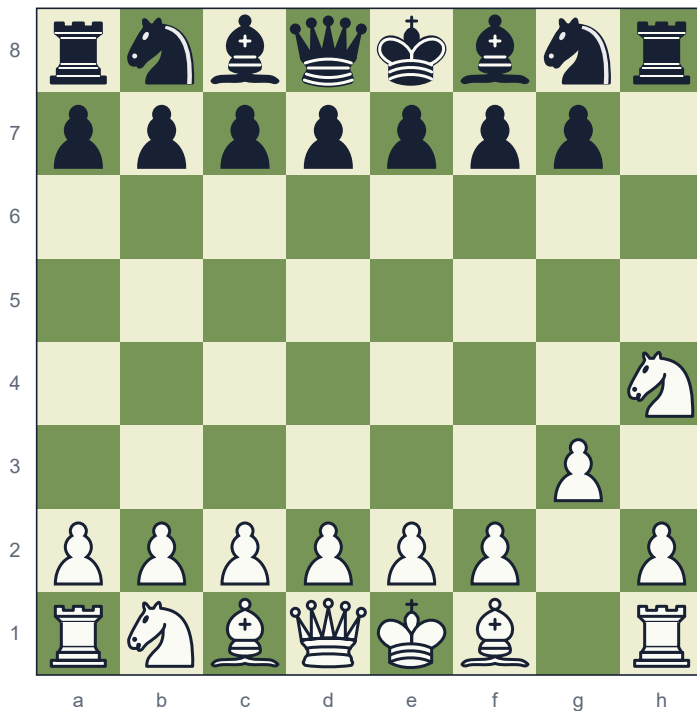
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can open the center before you complete the setup. Moving the bishop twice to preserve an image can waste valuable tempi.

BOARD DRILL

Replay the ...Bb4+ branch and compare Bd2 with a pawn block using legal moves and resulting development.

When Black attacks with h-pawns



HW-13 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

The g3 pawn gives the king bishop a square but offers a target for ...h5-h4. White must judge whether the advance is supported and whether central counterplay is available.

HOW TO DECIDE

Against an unsupported rush, development may permit a capture. Against a prepared attack, compare restraint, exchanges and a central break. Count rook lines before castling.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

A pawn on h3 can become a hook for ...g4 or ...h4. Stopping one move is not the same as solving the whole attack.

BOARD DRILL

Compare the immediate ...h5 line with the supported ...h5 line. Explain why the same response is not automatic.

A missing fianchetto bishop



HW-16 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

After ...Bh3 and an exchange on h3, the queen approaches dark squares near White's king. The bishop that used to defend those squares is gone.

HOW TO DECIDE

Inspect checks, queen entry squares and pawn levers. Develop with tempo if possible and consider whether a central challenge is faster than a passive defense.

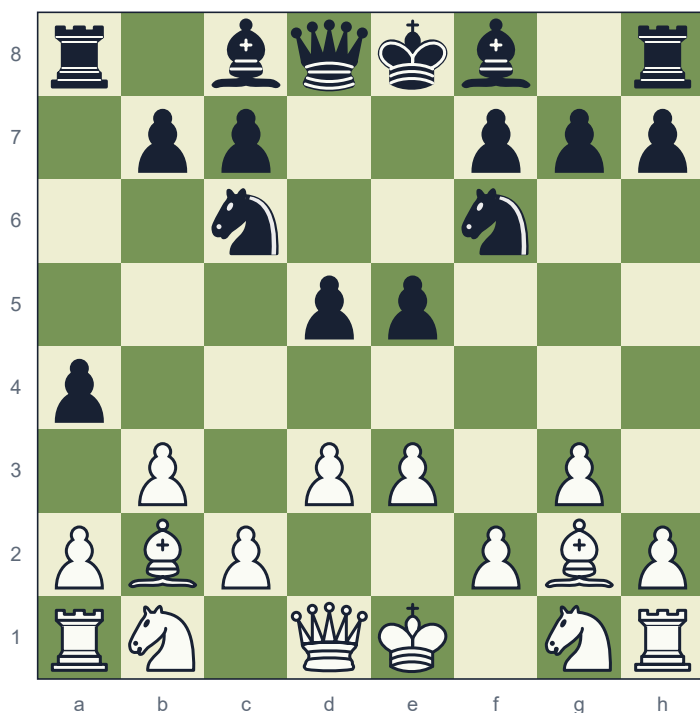
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may combine ...h5 with queen pressure. Castling short into a concrete attack can be worse than keeping the king central temporarily.

BOARD DRILL

Point to three squares the g2 bishop used to cover and examine which become relevant after the exchange.

Queenside pawn contacts



HW-17 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

With b3 and Bb2, a black ...a5-a4 advance challenges the pawn cover in front of the bishop and rook. This matters even if White plans to castle short.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate bxa4, a3 and maintaining tension. Trace opened files and count defenders of the bishop. Compare a central response if Black spends several wing tempi.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

The a1 rook can become exposed after exchanges, and the bishop may lose a safe retreat. A pawn contact can create a piece tactic.

BOARD DRILL

Set up the ...a4 endpoint and list the pieces behind the pawns before calculating any capture.

Transitioning to normal active play



HW-20 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

A KIA, Reti or central fianchetto position may be the best result of a flexible opening. The course deliberately includes these departures so the Hippo does not become a cage.

HOW TO DECIDE

Name the new pawn structure and use its plans. If e4 leads to a French-type KIA, support e5; if c4 opens the d-file, contest that file.

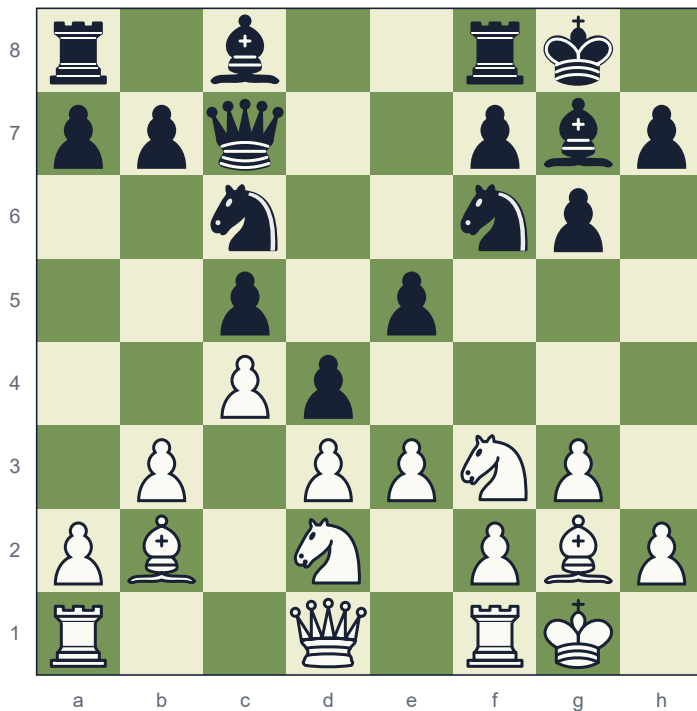
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can change the center again. A successful transition still requires the same threat and blunder checks on every move.

BOARD DRILL

Choose one adaptation as your default when the full setup looks too slow, and practice that endpoint for three games.

Loose pieces and forks



HW-03 audit position - White to move

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Find two pieces that would be vulnerable if their defender moved. Calculate one legal forcing move that tests the relation. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can advance ...d4 and restrict the b1 knight. The g7 bishop may become stronger than its white counterpart after exchanges.

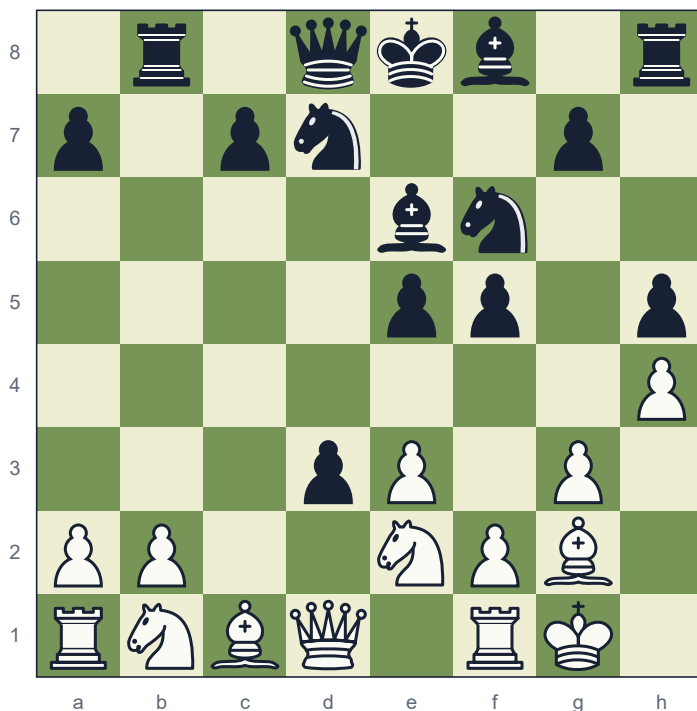
A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

CALCULATION SKILL

Before calculating an attack, list undefended pieces. A knight fork attacks two targets that cannot both move away. A queen check may combine king pressure with a second target. If you remove a defender, inspect every piece it protected.

Pins and discovered attacks



HW-08 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

An absolute pin prevents a piece from moving if doing so exposes its king. A relative pin involves a valuable piece behind it, usually the queen. A discovered attack appears when a blocking piece moves away. Always trace the entire line, including the piece behind the blocker.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Identify a line piece, its blocker and the target behind it. If no pin exists, explain which required element is missing. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

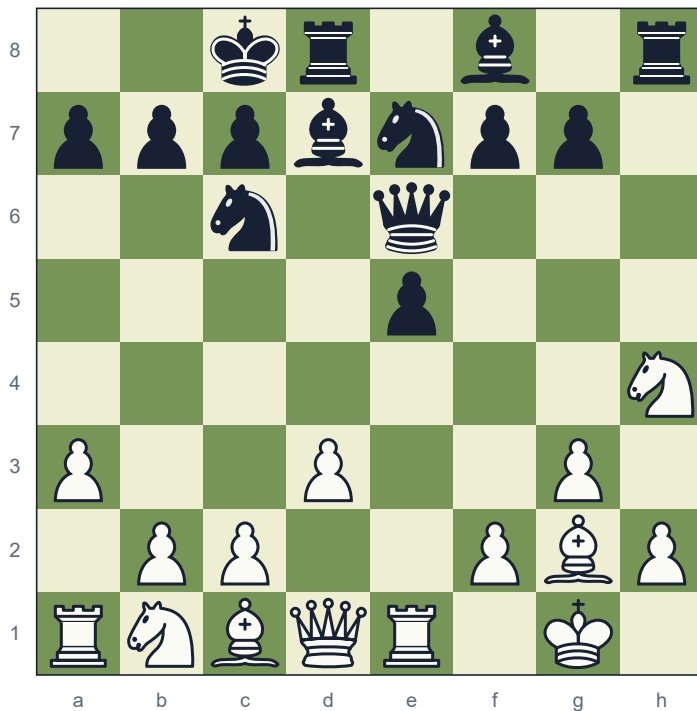
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black may push ...e4 or ...f4 with tempo. A slow double fianchetto can become a target if the center opens before White castles.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Intermediate moves and defensive resources



HW-13 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

A recapture is not compulsory unless it is the only legal response to check. Before recapturing, inspect checks, stronger captures and direct threats. When attacking, give the defender the same opportunity; do not assume automatic recaptures.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

At a capture in your line, pause before the reply. List all legal checks, then compare them with the expected recapture. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

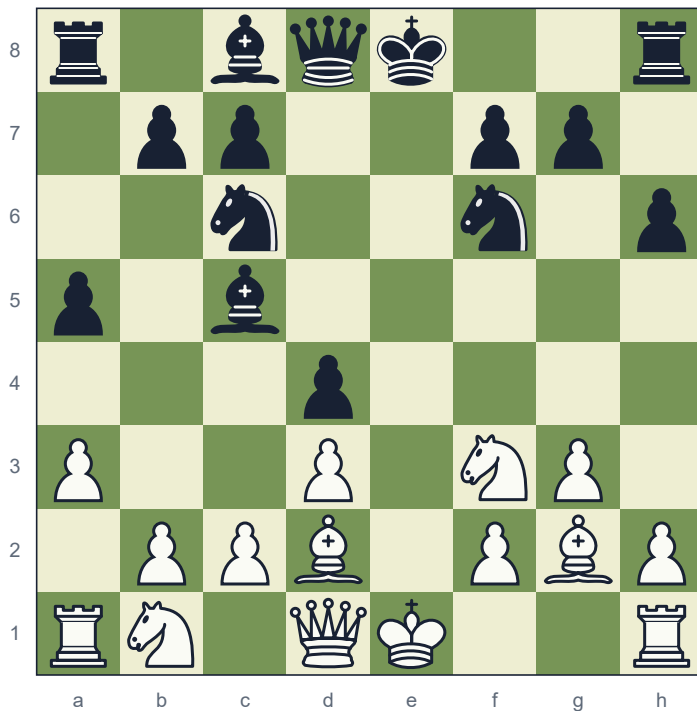
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black may strike in the center while the knight sits on the rim. Do not keep chasing pawns instead of developing.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

A sacrifice needs a stopping point



HW-18 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Calculate a sacrifice until the defender has a stable reply you can evaluate. Count material after the whole sequence, not after the first capture. If the line ends only with a vague promise of attack, compare a non-sacrificial candidate.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Choose a tempting sacrifice from a laboratory or your own game. Write the best defensive reply and the position where you stop calculating. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

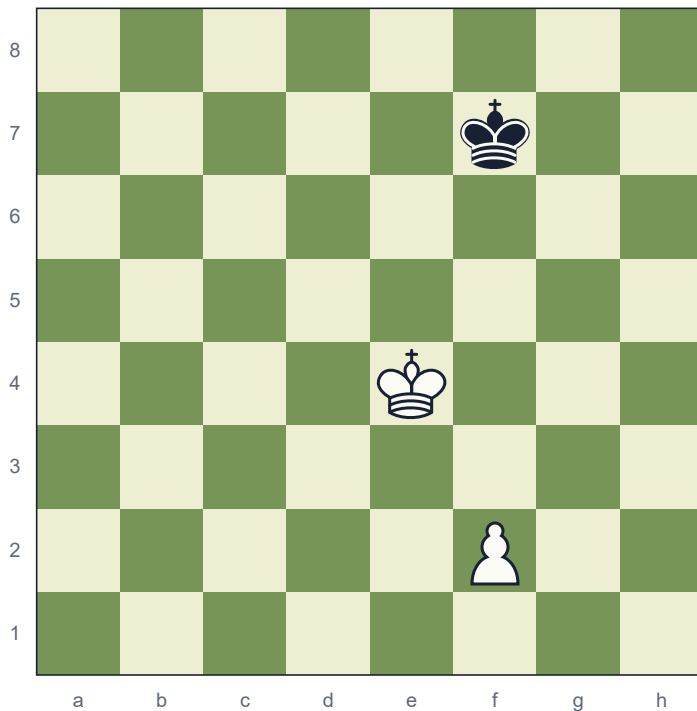
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Moving a pawn to block without checking the resulting weaknesses may cost time. A fixed formation is no reason to choose an inferior response to check.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Activate the king when queens are gone



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

White to move: Kf5 is a legal active king move. Kf4 is also legal but less direct; compare plans rather than inventing a forcing win. The general lesson is to bring the king toward the pawn and useful squares while keeping the opposing king out.

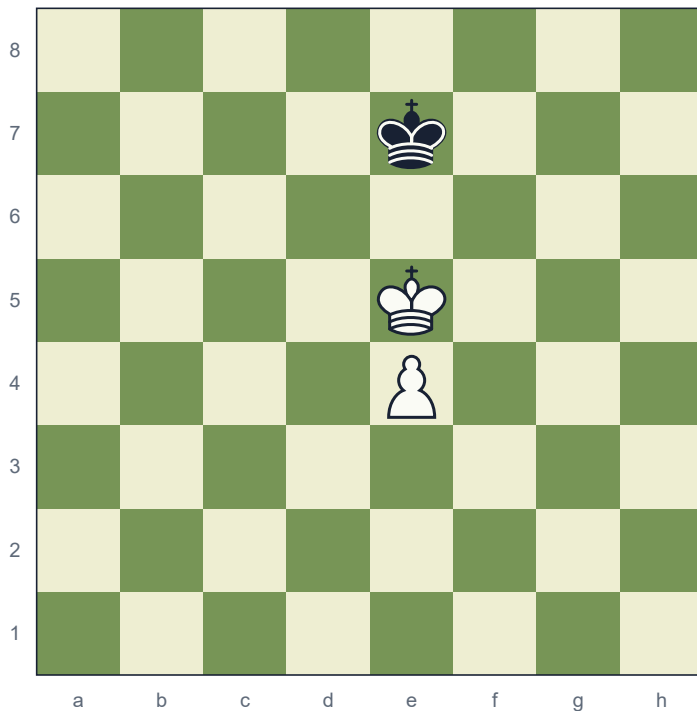
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In an opening-to-endgame transition, first inspect checks and pawn threats, then activate the king. Do not continue making shelter moves whose main purpose was defense against a queen. A rook ending may still require care about checks from behind.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Opposition and the importance of the move



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The kings face each other on e5 and e7 with one square between. White to move must give way or move the pawn; the geometry changes if Black is to move. Opposition is a tool for gaining entry squares, not a rule that always wins.

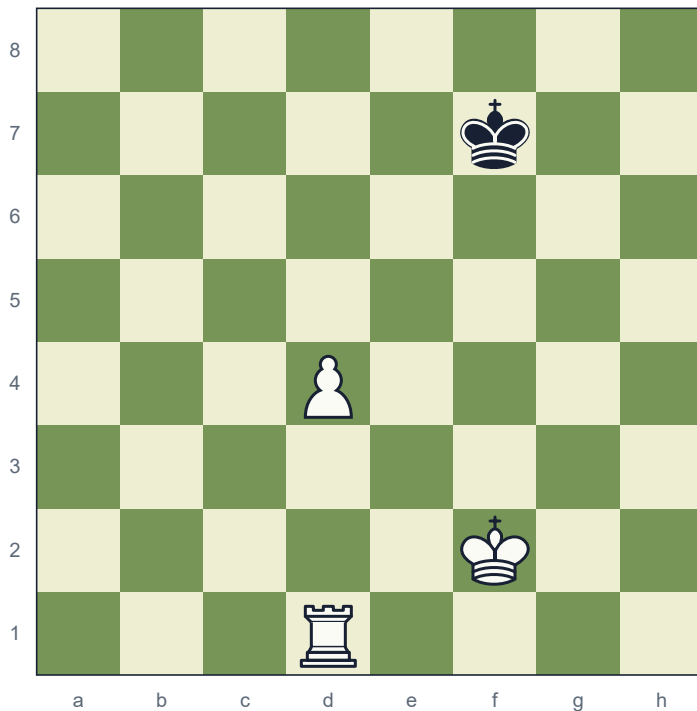
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Replay both side-to-move versions. Track the pawn's key squares and whether the attacking king can reach them. If you exchange into a pawn ending, calculate the actual king route and tempo rather than relying on the extra pawn alone.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Rooks belong where they work



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The rook on d1 stands behind its own passed d-pawn. As the pawn advances, the rook can continue supporting it from behind. This is a teaching position, not a claim of a difficult theoretical win against a rook.

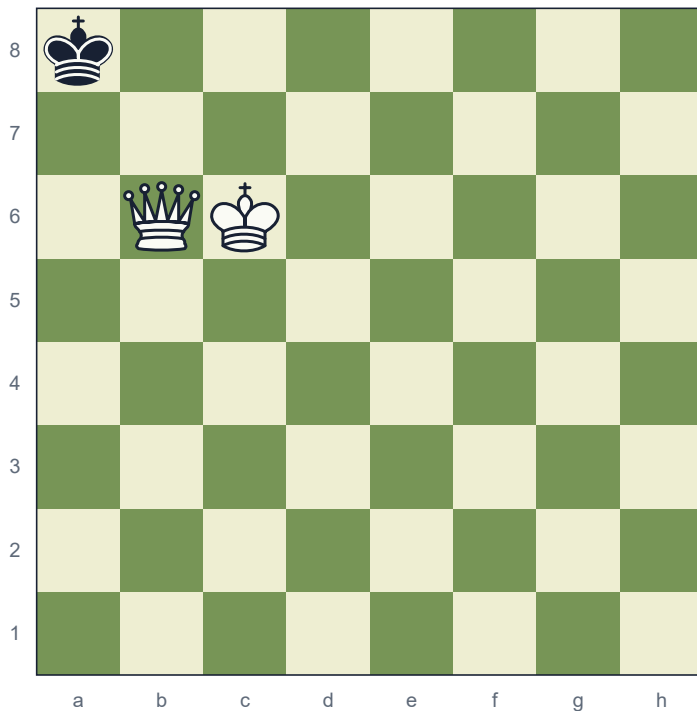
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In real rook endings compare activity, checking distance, king shelter and pawn races. Putting a rook behind a passed pawn is a useful default, but a tactical threat or a decisive lateral check can override it. Do not trade an active rook into a lost pawn ending.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Recognize stalemate before promoting



Teaching position - Black to move

READ THE BOARD

Black to move is not in check and has no legal move: a7 and b8 are controlled by Qb6, while b7 is controlled by the queen and Kc6. This is stalemate, so the position is a draw despite White's extra queen.

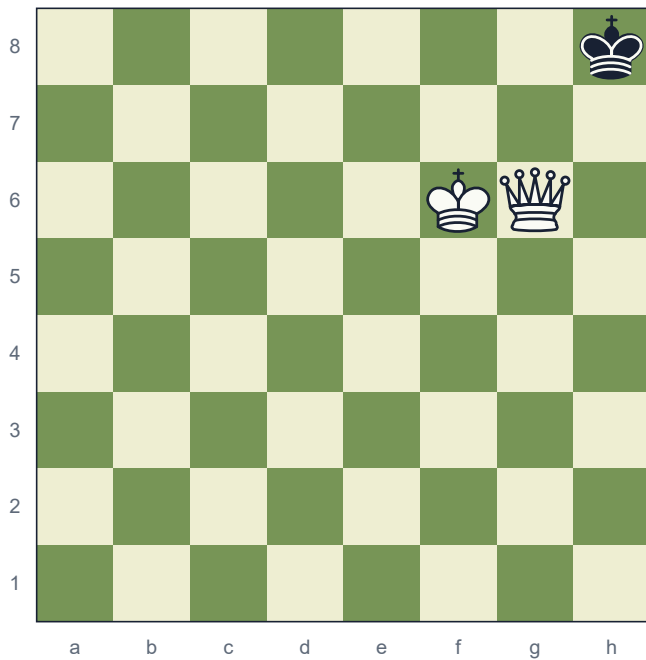
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Before delivering the final move of a won game, check whether the opponent has a legal reply if not in check. In queen-versus-king technique, restrict the king with the queen, approach with your king and preserve a legal waiting square until you can give mate.

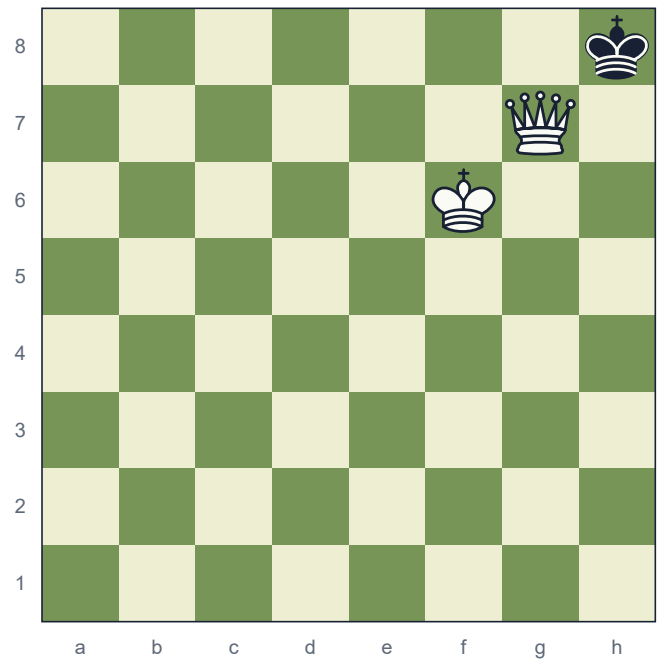
PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Finish a won queen ending



White to move - find mate in one



After Qg7# - Black is checkmated

WHY THIS IS MATE

Qg7 gives check along the g7-h8 diagonal. The white king on f6 protects the queen, so ...Kxg7 is illegal. The queen controls g8 and h7, removing the remaining escape squares. This proof checks attacks and legal replies, not just the appearance of the diagram.

TECHNIQUE BEFORE THE FINAL MOVE

Use the queen to reduce the enemy king's space, bring your king close enough to support the mate, and keep a legal waiting square until you can give checkmate. A queen alone can accidentally stalemate; review the previous lesson before repeating this drill.

Choosing the right exchanges

DO NOT TRADE BY HABIT

When offered a trade, compare the activity of the pieces leaving the board, the resulting pawn weaknesses and the king positions. A player with less space may welcome exchanges, but trading the only active piece can make the position worse.

PAWN ENDING TEST

Before exchanging the last pieces, calculate king activity, passed-pawn races and the side to move. Opposition is one tool; it is not a substitute for counting legal tempi. A pawn ending is often less forgiving than a rook ending.

OPENING-SPECIFIC QUESTION

A KIA, Reti or central fianchetto position may be the best result of a flexible opening. The course deliberately includes these departures so the Hippo does not become a cage.

PRACTICAL CONVERSION

When ahead, neutralize counterplay and improve the least active piece before collecting another pawn. When defending, seek active checks, pawn breaks and useful exchanges rather than passive waiting.

A STUDY HABIT

After every practice game, keep one transition position. Record which exchange you chose, which alternative you considered and how the pawn structure changed.